

## **The Introductory Word and the First and the Second Dialogues Between the Prophet and Jehovah**

Scripture Reading: Hab. 1:1-17; 2:1-4

In this message we will begin to consider the book of Habakkuk. We will cover the introductory word, the first dialogue between the prophet and Jehovah, and the first part of the second dialogue between these parties. As we will see, the one golden verse in Habakkuk is 2:4: “The righteous one will live by his faith.” This verse is related to God’s eternal salvation, to His salvation of our whole being — spirit, soul, and body. Everything else in Habakkuk is a background for the release of the revelation concerning God’s eternal salvation of sinners. We may compare the book of Habakkuk to a walnut and then say that this verse is the “kernel” of the “walnut.” Thus, as we read Habakkuk, we should focus our attention on this one verse.

### **I. The introductory word**

The introductory word is found in 1:1.

#### **A. The meaning of the name Habakkuk**

The name Habakkuk in Hebrew means “embracing” or “clinging to,” signifying that we need to seek God by embracing Him or clinging to Him. For us to receive God’s eternal salvation, we need to be embraced by God, and we need to cling to Him.

Eternal salvation is actually God Himself. God does not save us by remaining in the heavens and stretching out His arm to reach the earth. In order to save us, God became a man on this earth and came to us. The central thought of the four Gospels is that the saving God came out of eternity into time, out of the heavens to earth, and out of divinity into humanity to be a man. In this way He could embrace man and man could cling to Him.

While God was saving us, He was not in the appearance, the form, of God. Rather, He was in the form of a man named Jesus. Hosea 11:4 tells us that God draws us with the cords of a man, with the bands of love. The saving cords of love are Christ’s humanity. The account of Zaccheus in Luke 19:1-10 shows us the way God saves us by coming to us. In order to be saved by God, we must be embraced by God and we must cling to Him.

#### **B. The time of Habakkuk’s ministry**

The time of Habakkuk’s ministry was about 626 B.C. This was close to the time of the Babylonian invasion and the exile to Babylon.

#### **C. The place of his ministry**

The place of his ministry was Judah.

#### **D. The object of his ministry**

The object of his ministry was the southern kingdom of Judah.

#### **E. The subject**

The subject of Habakkuk’s ministry is the righteous judgment of God first on Israel by the Chaldeans and then on the Chaldeans by the nations. First, God judged His elect; God’s judgment begins from His house (1 Pet. 4:17). Then God turned His judgment to the Chaldeans, using the nations to judge them. The Babylonian Empire was defeated by the Medo-Persian Empire; the Medo-Persian Empire was defeated by the Greek Empire; the Greek Empire was defeated by the Roman Empire; and the Roman Empire, restored under Antichrist, will be defeated by Christ in His coming to destroy the entire human government, as described in Daniel 2:31-44.

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#### **F. The central thought**

The central thought of Habakkuk is this: the righteous God will judge both the evil Israel and the violent Chaldeans, and only the righteous one shall live by his faith (2:4b), that all the earth may know the glory of Jehovah (2:14) and be silent before Jehovah, who is in His holy temple (2:20), and that His seeker may sing to Him in prayer, in lauding, and in trusting in Him (ch. 3).

#### **G. The sections**

The book of Habakkuk has four sections: the introductory word (1:1); the first dialogue between the prophet and Jehovah (1:2-11); the second dialogue between the prophet and Jehovah (1:12—2:20); and the prophet’s song to Jehovah in prayer, lauding, and trusting in Him (3:1-19).

### **II. The first dialogue between the prophet and Jehovah**

The revelation in Habakkuk concerning God’s eternal salvation to sinners was brought out by a conversation between the prophet and God.

#### **A. The prophet’s inquiry of Jehovah**

In the first dialogue between the prophet and Jehovah, the prophet inquired of Jehovah concerning the iniquity, distress, destruction, and contention that he saw (v. 2-4). Regarding violence, he said, “How long, O Jehovah, shall I cry / And You do not hear? / I cry out to You, Violence! / And You do not save” (v. 2). According to the prophet’s view, violence was prevailing. Then the prophet went on to ask, “Why do You cause me to see iniquity / And look upon distress?” (v. 3a).

## **B. Jehovah's answer to the prophet**

In His answer to the prophet (vv. 5-11), Jehovah said that He was doing a work in the prophet's days which he would not believe if it were told to him (v. 5; cf. Acts 13:40-41). Then Jehovah said that He was raising up the Chaldeans, that bitter and hasty nation, who, being terrible and dreadful, would come to do violence and devastation on Judah (vv. 6-11).

## **III. The second dialogue between the prophet and Jehovah**

In verse 12 we have the beginning of the second dialogue between the prophet and Jehovah.

### **A. The prophet's inquiry of Jehovah**

Habakkuk 1:12—2:1 is the prophet's inquiry of Jehovah.

#### **1. Asking why Jehovah keeps silent when the Chaldeans swallow up His elect**

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In verse 12a the prophet said, "Are You not from everlasting, O Jehovah, / My God, my Holy One? We will not die." Then he said that Jehovah, the Rock, has appointed the Chaldeans to judgment. However, he went on to ask why He, who does not behold evil and who cannot look upon distress, looks upon them who deal treacherously and keeps silent when the wicked Chaldeans swallow up His elect, who are more righteous than they (vv. 12b-13). According to Habakkuk, the people of Israel were more righteous than the Babylonians, yet they were suffering the violence of the Babylonians. Habakkuk's word here indicates that he was angry with God.

#### **2. Saying that Jehovah makes man like the fish of the sea**

In verses 14 through 16 the prophet said that Jehovah makes man like the fish of the sea and like the creeping things; that they take all of them up with a hook, drag them off in their net, and gather them into their seine; and that they offer sacrifices to their net and burn incense to their seine. He then concluded his inquiry by asking, "Will they then empty their net / And continually slay the nations without sparing?" (v. 17).

#### **3. Standing and watching to see what Jehovah would speak to him**

After making his inquiry of Jehovah, the prophet stood and watched to see what Jehovah would speak to him and what He would reply concerning his complaint (2:1).

### **B. Jehovah's answer to the prophet**

In 2:2-20 we have Jehovah's answer to the prophet.

#### **1. Telling him to write the vision**

In His answer to the prophet, Jehovah told him to write the vision (concerning God's judgment on the Chaldeans) and render it plainly upon tablets, so that he who reads it might run (v. 2).

#### **2. The vision being yet for an appointed time**

Jehovah went on to say that the vision (concerning His dealing with the Chaldeans) was yet for an appointed time and that it hastened toward the end and would not lie. Though it tarried, the prophet should wait for it; for it will surely come; it will not delay (v. 3).

#### **3. The Chaldeans being puffed up, their soul not being upright within them, but the righteous one living by his faith**

In verse 4a Jehovah said that the Chaldeans were puffed up and that their soul was not upright within them. Surely it would be fair and just for Jehovah to judge them.

Of the books of the Minor Prophets, only Habakkuk shows us God's eternal salvation to sinners. This matter is revealed in 2:4b: "But the righteous one will live by his faith." The apostle Paul quoted this word three times in the New Testament (Rom. 1:17; Gal. 3:11; Heb. 10:38). Here, to live means to have life and live.

According to the background of Habakkuk, both Israel (God's elect) and Chaldeans (the nations) were under God's judgment. Under God's judgment all sinners, whether Jews or Gentiles, are destined to die (Rom. 6:23). How can sinners escape God's judgment and be saved eternally? The unique way for sinners to obtain God's eternal salvation is to believe in God's embodiment, Christ, that they may become righteous and be justified to have life and live.

God's eternal salvation is not merely to save our body from suffering but to save our whole being — spirit, soul, and body — for eternity (1 Thes. 5:23). The way for us to receive such a salvation is to believe in Christ so that we may be justified by God and thus be qualified to have life, the eternal life, the divine life, and live by that life (Rom. 3:24; 5:1-2; Eph. 2:8). This is the New Testament gospel in an Old Testament prophetic book.

## Message 2

### **Christ as the Linking Factor in Micah, Jonah, and Habakkuk and the Bible as the Divine Revelation Given by God's Speaking Through Man**

Scripture Reading: Micah 5:2; Jonah 1:17; Hab. 2:4

In the foregoing message we covered the introductory word, the first dialogue between the prophet and Jehovah, and the first part of the second dialogue between them, and in the next message we will cover the second part of this dialogue and the prophet's song to Jehovah. In this message, which is an insertion, I have the burden to say a word concerning two matters: Christ as the linking factor in the books of Micah, Jonah, and Habakkuk, and the Bible as the divine revelation given by God's speaking through man.

#### **Christ as the linking factor in Micah, Jonah, and Habakkuk**

Apparently, the books of Micah, Jonah, and Habakkuk are separate and are not linked together by anything. However, if we get into the intrinsic contents of these three books, we will see that there is a linking factor and that this linking factor is Christ.

#### **Christ's origin and birth**

Micah 5:2 says, "You, O Bethlehem Ephrathah, / So little to be among the thousands of Judah, / From you there will come forth to Me / He who is to be Ruler in Israel; / And His goings forth are from ancient times, / From the days of eternity." Here we see that Christ is the eternal One; His origin is in eternity. But one day He was born as a man in Bethlehem. Thus, here we have Christ's origin and birth.

#### **Christ's death and resurrection**

Jonah 1:17 says, "Jehovah prepared a great fish to swallow Jonah up, and Jonah was in the stomach of the fish for three days and three nights." Here Jonah is a type of Christ, who died, who was in the heart of the earth three days and three nights, and who then was resurrected (Matt. 12:40-41). Thus, in the type of Jonah, we see Christ's death and resurrection.

#### **The righteous one living by His faith**

In the book of Jonah, Jehovah's salvation was brought to the most evil city of the Gentiles through the preaching of the prophet. Today God's salvation has come to us through the preaching of the gospel. We have received and applied God's salvation by faith. This is what is mentioned in the one golden verse in the book of Habakkuk, 2:4: "The righteous one will live by his faith." By faith we have received the salvation that was prepared, completed, and consummated by Christ's coming forth, and as a result we now are believers constituting the Body of Christ. Eventually, those believers who are the overcomers will be with Christ when He comes to defeat His enemies and to set up His kingdom on the earth.

#### **The need to see something intrinsic**

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From the foregoing we can see that Christ Himself is the linking factor in the Minor Prophets. We have seen His origin, birth, death, and resurrection. We have also seen that through His going forth after His resurrection, God's complete salvation has come to us and that we have received it by faith.

Whereas we can see Christ as the linking factor, the worldly people see only the consuming factor (the locusts) and the suffering factor (Israel). For twenty-seven centuries Israel has been suffering under the locusts with their cutting, swarming, licking, and consuming (Joel 1:4). The newspapers are full of reports concerning the locusts and Israel. We need to see something more than what is reported in the newspapers. We need to see something intrinsic. This means that we need to see that Christ, the eternal One, has gone forth in His incarnation, crucifixion, and resurrection and that His going forth is continuing today as more believers are added to Him. We may compare His going forth to the movement of a train that makes various stops so that more goods can be loaded onto it. Christ is the "train" and we are the "goods" that are in Him. Eventually, this train with its goods will reach its destination.

#### **The Bible as the divine revelation given by God's speaking through man**

The Bible is the divine revelation through God's speaking. Regarding this, we need to realize that it is not easy for God to speak to human beings directly. In the Old Testament the incarnation had not yet been accomplished; however, God knew that He intended to become a man. His being incarnated was the first step of all His goings forth, and God was anticipating this. The principle according to the divine revelation is that God would not do anything directly but would do everything through man, with man, and in man.

### **Transferred out of Adam and into Christ**

The matter of God being in man is not clearly seen in the Old Testament, but in the New Testament, especially beginning from John, there are phrases like in Me (14:20) and abide in Me (15:4). We believe into the Lord Jesus (3:16), and now we are in Him. Before believing we were outside of Christ; we were in Adam. But one day we were transferred out of Adam and into Christ, the embodiment of the Triune God. Now we are persons in Christ. Unfortunately, not many Christians realize that genuine, living Christians are those who are actually and practically in Christ. The importance of being in Christ is stressed by Paul in his Epistles, where, especially in Ephesians, the short phrase in Christ is so frequently used.

### **The strong accent in the Old Testament**

In the Old Testament it is difficult to find a case which proves that God's people are those who have been transferred into the Triune God. Nevertheless, in each of the prophets' books, wherever they speak concerning Christ, that is the great point, the strong accent, of that book. For example, the strong accent of the book of Joel is not the locusts but the outpouring of the consummated Spirit. Actually, this is the accent of the entire Old Testament, for the outpouring of the Spirit is the practical realization of Christ, who is the living, compound, consummated, life-giving, and indwelling Spirit. This Christ is just the Triune God, consummated through the processes of incarnation, human living, death, resurrection, and ascension. But this is not all. Following His ascension is His being poured out, His coming down, to indwell man and mingle with man. This mingling implies a dispositional sanctifying, renewing, transforming, conforming, maturing, and glorifying. Eventually, this mingling makes us one with the divine person of the processed Triune God, whose embodiment is Christ and whose reality is the Spirit. Today this Spirit is the all-inclusive One indwelling us, moving in us, anointing us, and mingling with us.

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### **The kernel, the intrinsic part, of the Old Testament**

Christ is revealed in the Old Testament by the types, the prophecies, the historical writings, and the Psalms. The types of Christ, the prophecies concerning Christ, and the historical writings do not need to be purified, but we must study the Psalms in a purifying way. Among the first forty-one psalms, only seven present a clear revelation of Christ (Psa. 2, 8, 16, 22—24, 40). Psalm 1 is good, but it is good according to the natural concept. Still, this psalm is necessary, for without it, how could the beauty of Psalm 2 be manifested?

Let us use an orange tree as an illustration. In order to grow, an orange needs not only its peel but also the whole tree with the roots, the trunk, the branches, and the leaves. However, none of these should be eaten. Actually, to eat or drink, the only thing we need is the orange juice. This illustration points to something crucial related to the enjoyment of Christ, the eating of Christ. In order to see Christ in reality, we need all one hundred fifty of the psalms, but to enjoy Christ, to feed on Christ, we need to come to the revelation of Christ in the Psalms.

The Bible is the divine speaking, but this divine speaking is not something that has come directly by God Himself. This speaking is by God through man. For instance, God charged David to speak what is in Psalm 2, but because David was full of opinions and concepts and because he loved the law to the uttermost, he spoke Psalm 1. He added something of his own. Today when we come to the Bible, we may not know what is the real message and what is the human addition. This may be our situation when we come to the Minor Prophets. In these books there are some human concepts. When Jonah was angry with God and argued with God, he was expressing his own human concept. The vital point here is that whereas the entire Bible is the divine revelation, it is the kernel, the intrinsic part, that is good for eating and drinking to nourish us.

## Message 3

# The Second Dialogue Between the Prophet and Jehovah and the Prophet's Song to Jehovah

Scripture Reading: Hab. 2:5-20; 3:1-19

In this message we will continue to consider the second dialogue between the prophet and Jehovah and then go on to consider the prophet's song to Jehovah.

## 4. Five woes to the Chaldeans

After the prophet's inquiry of Jehovah (1:12—2:1), Jehovah answered Habakkuk (2:2-20), revealing His judgment upon the Chaldeans (vv. 5-20). In His answer to the prophet, Jehovah spoke concerning the five woes to the Chaldeans.

### a. The first woe

First, because the Chaldeans had plundered many nations, the Chaldeans would be plundered and made booty to the nations (vv. 5-8). After just over seventy years, God recompensed Babylon. While the king, Nebuchadnezzar's grandson, was feasting in his palace using the utensils from God's temple, he saw the vision of the writing on the wall (Dan. 5). In that same night, Darius the Mede defeated Babylon and killed the king.

### b. The second woe

Second, Jehovah judged the Chaldeans because of their taking evil gain for their houses by violence, sinning against their own soul (vv. 9-10). As a result of this judgment, the stone would cry out from the wall of their houses and the rafter would answer from the timber of the houses (v. 11).

### c. The third woe

Third, the Chaldeans would receive the righteous recompense for building cities by bloodshed and establishing towns by iniquity (v. 12). It was of Jehovah that the peoples toiled for vanity and that the earth would be filled with the knowledge of the glory of Jehovah as the water covers the sea (vv. 13-14). This is mysterious. While all these things are taking place, something particular, something mysterious would be happening on earth — the earth would be filled with the knowledge of the glory of Jehovah.

### d. The fourth woe

Fourth, because the Chaldeans made their neighbor drunken with poison in order to look at their nakedness and did violence, destruction, and bloodshed to their cities, they would be sated with shame, with the cup of Jehovah's right hand and with disgrace upon their glory (vv. 15-17).

### e. The fifth woe

Fifth, the Chaldeans made the graven idol, the molten idol, and the dumb idols and said to them, "Awake!" and "Arise!" Therefore, they would be cheated by the idols and gain no profit (vv. 18-19). Verse 20 concludes, "Jehovah is in His holy temple: / Be silent before Him, all the earth!"

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## IV. The prophet's song to Jehovah

Habakkuk 3:1-19 is the prophet's song to Jehovah.

### A. In prayer

First, we have the prophet's song in prayer (vv. 1-2). In his prayer he asked Jehovah to revive His work in those years (vv. 1-2a), and he asked Him to make it known in those years that He will remember compassion in wrath.

### B. In lauding

In lauding, the prophet praised God in His majesty and splendor (vv. 3-4), in His terrifying judgment on the nations (vv. 5-12), and in His salvation of His people and of His anointed one (vv. 13-15).

### C. In trusting in Jehovah

In verses 16 through 19 the prophet declares his trust in Jehovah.

## 1. The prophet trembling in his place

Verse 16a says that the prophet, after hearing the voice of Jehovah, trembled in his place, with his lips quivering at the sound and rottenness entering his bones. Habakkuk's writing here is quite poetic.

## **2. The prophet waiting for the day of distress**

In verse 16b the prophet went on to say that he had to wait quietly for the day of distress, when the Chaldeans, the ones attacking (or invading) Israel, would come up against the people.

## **3. The prophet exulting in Jehovah and rejoicing in the God of His salvation, and Jehovah the Lord being His strength**

"For the fig tree will not sprout, / And there will be no yield on the vines; / The labor on the olive tree will fail, / And the fields will make no food; / The flock will be cut off from the fold, / And there will be no herd in the stalls. / Yet I will exult in Jehovah; / I will rejoice in the God of my salvation. / Jehovah the Lord is my strength; / And He makes my feet like hinds' feet / And will cause me to walk on my high places" (vv. 17-19a). These verses indicate that in a dark time, a time when there was nothing, Habakkuk trusted in Jehovah.

All these verses seem very good, but for the most part they express Habakkuk's natural concept, without much revelation of Christ. Even Habakkuk's concept of trusting in Jehovah during a time of need was natural. There is no comparison between these verses and Paul's writings. Paul's concept was different. When he was troubled, he prayed three times, but the Lord told him that He would not remove the thorn and that His grace was sufficient for him (2 Cor. 12:7-10). When Paul was short of food, he did not "trust" in the Lord in the way Habakkuk did; rather, he took the opportunity to fast. In a very real sense, he did not need to trust in the Lord, for he was in the Lord already, and the Lord was in him. Furthermore, instead of trying to keep the law, he lived Christ (Gal. 2:20; Phil. 1:21a).

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Whereas many Christians appreciate verses such as Habakkuk 3:17-19a, we need to be brought into another realm, the realm of Christ. These verses are not according to the divine revelation concerning Christ but according to the prophet's natural, human, and religious concept. If we are brought into the realm of Christ, we will not appreciate the natural, religious thought expressed in much of the Old Testament. Rather, we will treasure the divine revelation in the Word. Moreover, instead of "trusting" in the Lord like Habakkuk did, we will see that the crucial matter is not trusting but realizing that we are in Christ and that Christ is in us.

In our reading of the book of Habakkuk, we should not appreciate those things that fit in with our natural, religious concept but are not according to the divine revelation. This is why I emphasize the fact that the one matter we need to treasure in Habakkuk is found in 2:4b — the righteous shall have life and live by faith.

More than sixty years ago I read something by Brother Nee which said that it is wrong to pray and ask the Lord to help us. At that time I did not understand what he meant. However, I have learned from experience that the only prayer that gives me joy is this: "Praise You, Lord. You are one with me. Regardless of how weak and poor I am, I am in You and You are in me." But suppose I pray, "Lord, I still need Your help. I am weak and poor, and I have nothing. I ask You to come in to help me." If I were to pray in this way, the joy would be gone.

Concerning prayer, we should take Paul as our example, not Habakkuk. Paul did not pray for common things. On the contrary, he prayed that "the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of glory, may give to you a spirit of wisdom and revelation in the full knowledge of Him" (Eph. 1:17). We all need to have our view uplifted.

## **D. The song being for the choir director**

The last part of verse 19 says that the song of the prophet is for the choir director, with the prophet's stringed instrument.